

Self-harm

Someone self-harms when they do something to hurt their body. They might do this as a way of dealing with very difficult feelings or situations. There is no single cause, but for many who self-harm, it's a physical response to some overwhelming stress or sadness.

What is self-harm?

Self-harm is the act of deliberately hurting oneself. People may do this in a variety of ways. The most common is cutting, but other methods include burning, hair-pulling, ingesting harmful substances, pinching, punching walls or doors, and scratching. Taking dangerous risks, not looking after oneself, and exercising obsessively might also be considered forms of self-harm.

▷ Dangerous risks

While cutting or hair-pulling are more commonly acknowledged as self-harm behaviors, teens taking dangerous risks may also be seeking to hurt themselves.



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The truth about self-harm

It isn't just girls who self-harm.

Although it's more widely known among girls, boys also self-harm. Some self-harm behaviors may not be identified as such—for example, punching a wall or taking risks that result in injury.

Self-harm isn't attention-seeking.

In fact, self-harm is often kept secret.

Most people who self-harm don't want to end their life. For most, it's actually a coping mechanism.

Self-harm isn't a mental illness.

However, self-harm is associated with some mental illnesses, such as anxiety, depression, eating disorders, and post-traumatic stress.

Why people self-harm

There can be many reasons why someone would self-harm. It is sometimes described as a "relief valve"—a way to cope with emotions that might otherwise feel unbearable. For some, physical pain provides an escape or a distraction from emotional distress, while others self-harm to express low self-esteem or to punish themselves. It may also be a suicide attempt.

▽ Overwhelming feelings

Self-harm often happens during times of anger, distress, depression, fear, low self-esteem, or worry. It can become a cycle that is hard to break, as the harmful behaviors used to relieve difficult or painful feelings in turn lead to feelings of guilt or shame.

Periods of high stress and pressure, such as exams

Relationship difficulties, arguments, and breakups

Traumatic events, such as a bereavement or family breakdown, and their anniversaries

Wanting to escape from something

Feeling rejected, powerless, anxious, angry, or depressed

Finding it hard to communicate or express emotions

Bullying, controlling friendships, or controlling relationships

Witnessing or being subjected to physical, sexual, or emotional abuse